

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA**Notice the specific work -> Name it aloud -> Do not qualify****MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE**

Name one piece of effort you noticed today that would normally go unacknowledged. Say it without qualifying it or immediately moving on.

BEST FOR

- Managing or leading people
- Motivating someone who is working hard but not being recognised
- Strengthening loyalty and trust
- Preventing burnout in yourself and others

PHRASE BANK**Effort Acknowledgements · Naming the work**

- "I can see how much work went into that."
- "That took real effort and it shows."
- "I noticed how much you put into this — I wanted to say it."
- "That was not easy and you did it anyway."
- "I know that took longer than it should have — and you still got it done."
- "The amount of care in that was visible."
- "That was a lot to carry and you handled it."
- "I saw what went into this. I did not want to let it pass."

Specific Effort · Naming the particular thing

- "The preparation you put into that meeting was clear."
- "You did not have to go that far — and you did."
- "That was more thorough than it needed to be, and it made the difference."
- "You stayed through the hard part without cutting corners."
- "I noticed you did X even though nobody asked you to."

Quick Acknowledgements · Brief notice in passing

- "I saw the hours in that. Thank you."
- "That was a slog and you did it well."
- "Nice work staying on that until it cracked."
- "I know that was not fun. It mattered."
- "You carried that one. Noted."
- "That took patience I do not have. Thank you."

Professional Acknowledgement · Naming the labour in work settings

- "Before we review the outcome, I want to acknowledge the work rate that got us here."
- "The reason this migration felt uneventful is that months of preparation made it uneventful."
- "The polish on this did not happen by accident — someone gave up their evenings for it."
- "I want the effort behind this minuted, not just the result."
- "This ran smoothly because of preparation nobody saw. I saw it."
- "Whatever the outcome of the pitch, the quality of the preparation was exceptional."

Effort Repairs · When the work went unacknowledged

- "I went straight to feedback yesterday and skipped over the work itself. That was wrong — the effort was enormous."
- "I have been taking your reliability for granted. I want to stop doing that."
- "I realise I have never actually said this out loud: I see how much you carry."
- "My criticism landed before my acknowledgement. Let me reverse the order."
- "You have been doing the invisible work for months and I let it stay invisible. I am sorry."
- "The result got all my attention and the effort got none. That was unfair."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Moving straight to the next task without acknowledgement

Better: Good work on that.

Best: I know how much work went into that. I did not want to move past it without saying so.

2. Weak: Generic praise: 'You worked so hard!'

Better: That was a demanding piece of work.

Best: The preparation you put into that presentation was clear — especially under that timeline.

3. Weak: Backhanded acknowledgement: 'Finally got there!'

Better: It took a while but we got there.

Best: Clean acknowledgement of the effort, no qualifiers.

DECISION TREE

If Someone finishes a difficult piece of work

Acknowledge the work before moving to the next item.

"Before we move on — I want to say that took real effort and it shows."

If Someone is doing invisible work that goes unnoticed

Name it specifically and without prompting.

"I noticed you have been doing X — that does not go unnoticed."

If You want to acknowledge effort but do not want to sound patronising

Keep it simple and specific. One sentence. No fuss.

"That took a lot. I wanted to say so."

If The result was good but the effort was exceptional

Acknowledge the effort separately from the result.

"The result speaks for itself — but I also wanted to name what it took to get there."

SCENARIOS

Team member delivers after a difficult sprint

Name the effort before moving to what comes next. — "Before we get into the next phase — I want to acknowledge what that just took."

Colleague going through a hard period personally while maintaining output

Name the effort without making it about the personal situation. — "I see what you are carrying right now. I wanted to say it."

Peer who quietly fixed a problem nobody else noticed

Name the specific invisible work. — "I noticed you sorted that out on your own. That is the kind of thing that keeps things working."

Child or young person who tried hard regardless of outcome

Acknowledge the trying, not just the result. — "I saw how hard you worked on that. That matters more than the score."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the effort was poor and naming it implies the outcome is acceptable.
- When managing underperformance — naming effort can inadvertently reward the wrong behaviour.
- When your acknowledgement would be read as performative because no real follow-through is planned.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice before speaking

In one interaction today, pause before moving to the next topic and ask: 'Did I acknowledge what just happened?'

Day 2 — The specific naming

Give one acknowledgement that names the specific work rather than just 'good job.'

Day 3 — Invisible work

Acknowledge one person doing work that nobody else is noticing.

Day 4 — Effort vs outcome

Practise separating acknowledgement of effort from assessment of result.

Day 5 — No qualifier

Give one acknowledgement with no 'but', no 'although', and no 'next time' after it.

Day 6 — Written acknowledgement

Send one short message to someone acknowledging a specific effort.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did acknowledgements land well? Were any too vague? Did any feel like performance rather than genuine notice?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the effort before commenting on the result?
- Did I name the specific work — not just 'good job'?
- Did I say it without qualifying or immediately pivoting to the next ask?
- Was my acknowledgement genuine, not performative?
- Did I give the acknowledgement at the right moment — not too late?
- Did I acknowledge invisible or low-profile work that would normally go unnoticed?
- Did it land as genuine rather than managerial technique?